Methodology Report: *Fiction Without Hidden Facts*

Summary

Fiction Without Hidden Facts is a reply to Blumberg and Holguín, "Fictional Reality" (*Philosophical Review* 134(2), 2025). One AI system, Claude Opus 5.5, ran the project as orchestrator. It did the research, wrote every draft, and organised a staged review in which 43 separate AI agents read and criticised the work. The agents ran on three models: Claude Opus 5.5, Sonnet 5.5 and Haiku 5.5.

The human entrant did four things:

- chose the target paper by uploading it with the instruction "I'd like you to write something about this paper";
- set up a general, argument-neutral workflow;
- supplied PDFs of sources the AI asked for;
- made a small number of selection, approval and formatting decisions, listed in full in Human involvement.

The human supplied no thesis, argument, premise, distinction, example, objection or text, and did not edit the essay. Every substantive philosophical contribution in the essay originated with an AI agent. Where the ideas came from traces each one to the agent that produced it.

Elapsed time was about five hours on 23 October 2026, plus a final check on 26 October. Section Resources gives the token use and estimated cost.

Systems and tools

Models

Role	Model	Notes
Orchestrator	Claude Opus 5.5 (`claude-opus-5-5`)	Ran in a cloud agent session in the Claude app. It researched the topic, wrote all drafts and the final essay, triaged all feedback, and wrote this report.
Subagents: advisor, predictability test, priority ("-canon") checks, source check, screenings, final error check	Claude Opus 5.5	Each started in a fresh context with no access to the orchestrator's conversation, only the files named in its prompt.

Role	Model	Notes
Q&A audience: 30 agents over three rounds	Opus 5.5 (12), Sonnet 5.5 (9), Haiku 5.5 (9)	Models were mixed to get a spread of reactions; personas and focus were varied for the same reason.

The human set a standing restriction: no model above the Opus tier was used.

Tools available to the AI

- Web search and page fetching.
- A Linux workspace with Python. It was used to extract and search source texts, check quotations against them, check page ranges, and query the Crossref API for bibliographic data.
- Quarto and Typst, for typesetting.
- A file bridge to the human's computer. It was used only to deliver files to the project folder and to check the copies there.
- The human's own browser, through a browser extension. This was used once: to read one paywalled article, Oppy and Raivars 2026, with the human's institutional access.

Standing context

Two pieces of standing context were in place before this essay was started. Neither contains philosophical content.

1. **General user preferences in the Claude app.** These say that the user works in Quarto and wants honest feedback rather than flattery.
2. **A screening standard for the human's AI-written papers.** This is a document that defines four verdicts (NOT READY, PASS, PASS FORMAL, STRONG) and lists criteria a generalist journal editor applies at desk review:
   - positive contribution;
   - no obvious unanswered objections;
   - clarity;
   - engagement with the literature;
   - accuracy of quotation and citation;
   - priority over existing work.

   It was used unchanged, except for one instruction from the human about replies, described below.

No long-term memory containing philosophical ideas was used.

Human involvement

Every human input that bore on this essay is listed below, in order. Quotations are verbatim, and times are local to the human. Each entry has three parts:

- **Human:** what the human did.
- **AI:** what the AI did in response.

- **Classification:** where the input falls under the competition FAQ's lists of permitted and prohibited involvement.

1. 20 October: the workflow. This was set up for an earlier paper and reused here.

- **Human:** specified a seven-step workflow:
  1. idea from research;
  2. an advisor agent, with a return to step 1 if the idea is clearly flawed;
  3. rough draft;
  4. a ten-persona Q&A, one suggestion each;
  5. triage, with options including abandoning the paper and alerting the human;
  6. a Quarto paper under 6,000 words, with a carefully checked bibliography;
  7. screening against the standard above.

  Also: check citations carefully; if the result at step 7 is discouraging, tell the human rather than quietly retreat; use Opus at most.
- **AI:** followed the workflow (see The review process).
- **Classification:** permitted: "Creating argument-neutral agentic scaffolds or workflows"; "Giving generic methodological instructions".

2. 23 October, 07:55: the target paper.

- **Human:** uploaded the penultimate draft of Blumberg and Holguín, "Fictional Reality", and wrote: "I'd like you to write something about this paper." Added: "The instructions do say we're allowed to upload particular papers, so I think just saying 'Write about this' is just inside the limits. (We should be very clear in the report that we did this; if they decide this was a violation, we've at least been honest.)"
- **AI:** read the paper in full, found the existing replies, and began generating candidate theses.
- **Classification:** permitted: "Choosing a topic, question, debate, text"; "Providing a paper … for the AI to analyse"; compare the FAQ's example "Read these papers and respond to them."
- **Flagged:** this is the most directive input in the project, because it names a single target paper. It says nothing about what position to take on it.

3. 23 October, about 08:00: length.

- **Human:** "a 6k (or ideally less) paper on a recent Phil Review paper by high profile people is just about ok." "If you think it's worthwhile, we can get the actual Phil Review pages for quotes at the next stage."
- **AI:** asked for the published version (item 4).
- **Classification:** permitted: length and format guidance; an offer of source materials.

4. 23 October, 08:47, 09:02, 10:53 and 11:38: sources.

- **Human:** supplied PDFs the AI had asked for:
  - Khoo 2026;
  - the published Blumberg and Holguín;
  - McGonigal 2013, Caplan 2014 and Lee 2024;
  - Woodward 2012, Lewis 1978, Lewis 1976, and the published Williams and Woodward 2021;

  - Khoo 2022.
- **AI:** read each source in full where it was cited, and checked quotations and page numbers against it.
- **Classification:** permitted: "Providing a paper, passage, dataset, or body of literature". The AI chose every item and asked for it by name. The human chose none.

5. 23 October, 10:36: after the preliminary screening. The AI had reported that a preliminary screening judged the draft NOT READY, and had laid out options.

- **Human:** "I don't think you should worry about it seeming like a reply. There are so few original papers under 6000 words in the journals these days; I think a lot of papers will be replies. Just ask whether it is a good reply. I'm a bit more worried about targeting a secondary part of the paper."
- **AI:** added the first part to all later screening briefs, as an instruction from the project owner to judge whether the paper is a good reply rather than count the reply format against it. On the second part, the preliminary screener (an AI) had already objected that the draft's main test targeted a principle Blumberg and Holguín say does not drive their case. The AI restructured the paper so that its first argument answers their main argument (version 7).
- **Classification:** the first part is a methodological instruction about the screening standard. The second is generic feedback that names a general problem without giving a reason or a fix: "You may identify a general problem without explaining why it is a problem or how to solve it".
- **Flagged:** the remark selected which of the AI screener's concerns to treat as most serious. It contained no argument, no reason and no suggestion of how to fix the problem.

6. 23 October, 11:38: small corrections.

- **Human:** after the AI reported two PASS screenings and listed the small corrections the screeners had asked for, the human wrote: "make those small changes, then here is the Khoo".
- **AI:** made the listed corrections (version 7.1), then had version 7.1 screened twice more.
- **Classification:** permitted: approving AI-proposed revisions ("Asking one AI to evaluate or revise work produced by another").

7. 23 October, 12:15: optional revisions.

- **Human:** chose two of five optional revisions the AI had proposed after the second pair of screenings: "make the 3&5 changes before I render".
- **AI:** made those two revisions (version 7.2).
- **Classification:** permitted: selecting among AI outputs.

8. 23 October, 12:21 and 12:35: formatting.

- **Human:** typeset the essay on their own machine and reported that the check and cross characters (✓, ✗) were missing from the font and that a table rendered badly. Then asked: "Can you add a References header above the references? This is something Quarto does automatically for HTML, but not the other formats".
- **AI:** replaced the symbols with words, redesigned the table, and added the heading.
- **Classification:** permitted: "Performing mechanical formatting".

9. 26 October, 08:43: final check and this report.

- **Human:** asked for "one more read over to check for any mistakes, including checking the bibliography carefully", and for this report.
- **AI:** see Final check.
- **Classification:** permitted: "Asking the AI to check quotations, references, factual claims, or formal reasoning".

What the human did not do:

- write, rewrite or edit any part of the essay;
- propose or choose a thesis, an argument, a premise, a distinction, an example, a case or an objection;
- comment on the essay's philosophical content beyond the two sentences quoted at 10:36.

The human first saw the essay after it had passed two screenings.

One incident did not affect the essay. A Q&A agent created a stray scheduled reminder in the session. The AI did not remove it on the agent's behalf; it reported it to the human.

The review process

All of the following was organised by the AI orchestrator and carried out by AI agents. The agents worked in independent contexts and could read only the files named in their prompts. Every prompt is reproduced verbatim in the supplementary file `agent-prompts.md`.

Stage 1. Research and a candidate thesis (orchestrator)

The orchestrator read the target in full and found the two published replies:

- Oppy and Raivars 2026, read in full;
- Khoo 2026, read in the parts on fiction once the human supplied it.

It then wrote a candidate thesis. That thesis said the target's attitude data are the signature of attitudes held under a supposition, not evidence of hidden fictional facts.

Stage 2. Pre-tests of the candidate (two Opus agents, run in parallel)

- **Predictability test.** An agent read the target with the candidate hidden, wrote down the replies a competent specialist would most likely give, and only then read the candidate.
  - Its verdict was that the candidate's core thesis was *predictable*: it was the agent's top-ranked family of replies.
  - It raised the point that became the essay's "absorption" result: the target's view can mimic the candidate's on single-fiction attitudes.
  - *Disclosed defect:* the prompt's second-phase questions named the candidate's theme. So the first phase was blind to the candidate's text but not entirely to its topic. The agent flagged this itself.
- **Priority ("canon") check.** An agent searched for the candidate's ideas in the existing literature. It found them *partly anticipated* by Williams and Woodward 2021, which the essay now credits as a precursor.

Stage 3. Advisor (one Opus agent)

A fresh agent acting as a demanding senior advisor reviewed the idea memo. Its verdict was "promising but restructure".

- It identified the essay's best technical point: Scopelessness needs a single point of evaluation, not a single world.
- It judged one part of the candidate unsound (a "revelation dilemma"), and that part was dropped.
- It proposed a new argument about sequels that extend a story consistently.

A second priority check (Opus) on that sequel argument found it new. It also found that one step was overstated and that a repair was available. The draft was rebuilt to take account of both points.

Stage 4. Three rounds of audience Q&A (30 agents), each followed by triage

Each round, ten agents with different backgrounds read the current draft as if they had heard it as a talk. Each gave one suggestion of at most 450 words. The personas included:

- a defender of Stalnakerian selection semantics;
- a bilateral logician;
- an imaging epistemologist;
- an ontologist of serial art;
- a TV writer and a screenwriter;
- experimental semanticists;
- a Lewisian;
- an assessment relativist;
- a causal modeller;
- a Waltonian;
- generalist editors;
- in every round, a close reader of the target who checked every quotation.

After each round the orchestrator wrote a triage document. For each suggestion it decided whether to incorporate it, partly incorporate it, or reject it with reasons. It then chose among five options, ranging from writing up the paper to abandoning it.

Round	Draft read	Outcome
1	v3	Substantive revision; back to Q&A. The sequel data were shown to be explicit or work-level and so predicted by the target's own view. The semantics was made precise as a homogeneity logic, and the absorption result was restated with two explicit bridge principles.
2	v4	Substantive revision; back to Q&A. New temporal data were shown to be absorbed by the target's default rules. The orchestrator replaced them with a new "strengthening test" that compares adding a detail to a story with adding it to a counterfactual's antecedent.

Round	Draft read	Outcome
3	v5	Incorporate or reject each suggestion, then write. This round produced the "anchoring", "defaults" and "path-dependence" replies that the essay's §5 analyses. A screenwriter suggested replacing a trick toss with a gust. A close reader caught a misquotation.

Stage 5. Writing and source checking

The orchestrator wrote the essay in Quarto with a BibTeX bibliography.

- Every quotation from the target was checked by script against the published text.
- A source-check agent (Opus) checked the open-access sources the essay cites. Two citations it could not verify were dropped or replaced.
- The orchestrator asked the human for the remaining non-open-access sources. Quotations from them were checked against the PDFs.
- Journal entries in the bibliography were checked against Crossref.

Stage 6. Screening (Opus agents in fresh contexts)

Screening	Text	Verdict	What followed
Preliminary	v6	NOT READY	Reported to the human with options (see the 10:36 entry above). The AI restructured the paper: answer the target's main argument first, add the closest antecedent (Woodward 2012), introduce a "coupling" for comparing tellings, and change the title.
A and B (independent)	v7	PASS, FORMAL and PASS	Small corrections that the screeners asked for (approved by the human at 11:38).
C and D (independent)	v7.1	PASS, FORMAL and PASS	Two optional revisions, chosen by the human at 12:15 from the AI's list of five.
E and F (independent)	v7.3, the final text	PASS, FORMAL and PASS, FORMAL	At screener F's request, three sentences were qualified ("chances unchanged") so that the conclusion no longer contradicts a footnote. One sentence was cut to keep the length the same.

The screeners did not see one another's reports or the orchestrator's notes.

Stage 7. Final check, 26 October

The human asked for "one more read over to check for any mistakes, including checking the bibliography carefully". The orchestrator then did five things.

1. **Checked the bibliography.** It re-checked every DOI against Crossref (20 of 20 matched) and checked book and chapter entries against the target paper's own reference list. It checked web sources on the live pages. One web-page title was wrong.
2. **Recounted the words.** Counted on the rendered text, the essay was about 6,190 words excluding the bibliography, so over the limit. Earlier counts had been taken on the source file, where a citation such as "(Lewis 1978, 42)" is a short key. The orchestrator cut about 350 words of restatement and compression without changing any argument.
3. **Commissioned an independent error check.** A fresh Opus agent, which had not seen the work being produced, checked the essay against the source texts. It reported four must-fix items:
   - the word count;
   - an AI model's name in the document's metadata, which showed in the HTML version;
   - a misreported judgement about *doubt*;
   - one option in §5 that contradicted §4.

   It also reported ten should-fix and fifteen minor items, and confirmed every quotation and page reference. The orchestrator checked each item against the sources and fixed all but two: one minor point of citation style (how page ranges are abbreviated) and one item that needed no change.
4. **Commissioned two final screenings** of the exact text to be submitted, by two fresh Opus agents. They used the same brief as the previous pair, apart from the file name, and both returned PASS, FORMAL. One screener pointed out that the conclusion said a detail added to a story "cannot" change an open outcome, while a footnote allows a change when the detail alters the chances. Three sentences were qualified to match the footnote, and one sentence was cut so that the length did not change. These edits are the only differences between the text screened and the text submitted.
5. **Logged the changes** in the project notes and a change list.

Numbers

- **Candidate theses and arguments generated and assessed.** At least five main lines:
  1. the suppositional-attitude thesis;
  2. a revelation dilemma (dropped as unsound);
  3. the sequel argument (rebuilt, then superseded);
  4. a temporal datum (absorbed by the target's defaults, so replaced);
  5. the strengthening test with coupling (kept).
- **Drafts:** five Markdown drafts (v1–v5), then Quarto versions v6, v7, v7.1 and v7.2, and the final v7.3.
- **AI agents other than the orchestrator, 43 in all:**
  - predictability test;
  - two priority checks;

  - advisor;
  - 30 Q&A participants;
  - source check;
  - seven screenings;
  - final error check.
- **Final length:** 5,838 words. That count covers the rendered text, including title, abstract, footnotes and in-text citations, and excludes the bibliography. A cruder count of the PDF text, which counts every mathematical symbol as a word, gives 5,987.
- **Screenings:** seven, by seven different agents. One was preliminary (NOT READY); two each were of v7 and v7.1; two were of the final text.

Where the ideas came from

Every substantive contribution in the essay originated with an AI agent:

Contribution in the essay	Origin
Story-state semantics: claims evaluated against the information a work provides, weighted by a Reality Principle for credence	Orchestrator's candidate thesis. The bilateral, homogeneity form came from the advisor and the Q&A bilateral logician.
Scopelessness needs a single point of evaluation, not a single world	Advisor agent
Absorption: given two bridge principles, the target's view and the story-state view agree on every attitude toward a single fiction	Risk identified by the predictability-test agent. The bridge principles were required by the Q&A imaging epistemologist. The orchestrator turned it into a result.
The strengthening test (the reunion special and sentences (A)–(D))	Orchestrator, after Q&A round 2
Maximal coupling for comparing tellings	Orchestrator (version 7)
The analysis of the surviving single-world views: anchoring, defaults, path-dependence, supervaluation	Q&A agents (selection semanticist, causal modeller, Stalnakerian defender) and the second priority check; written up by the orchestrator
Positioning against precursors (Lewis 1978, Williams and Woodward 2021, Woodward 2012, Khoo 2022 and 2026)	Priority checks and screenings; written up by the orchestrator

Resources

Elapsed time. About 4 hours 40 minutes on 23 October 2026 (07:55 to 12:35 local), from upload to the final formatting fix. The final check, the screenings and this report on 26 October took about one hour (08:43 to 09:40).

Machine time. The 40 subagents run on 23 October used 292 agent-minutes in total. Most ran in parallel: the ten Q&A agents in each round, and the screenings in pairs.

Tokens (subagents, 23 October). These figures come from the session logs.

Model	Agents	Output tokens	Cache-read tokens	Cache-write tokens	Cost at API list prices
Claude Opus 5.5	22	2.69 M	182.4 M	9.30 M	$165
Claude Sonnet 5.5	9	0.56 M	15.0 M	1.41 M	$13
Claude Haiku 5.5	9	1.25 M	23.3 M	2.82 M	$1–7
Total	**40**	**4.50 M**	**220.6 M**	**13.5 M**	**about $180**

Tokens (26 October).

- The three subagents used 0.57 M output tokens, 48.5 M cache-read tokens and 1.83 M cache-write tokens, about $36 at list prices: the error check $18 and the two screenings $9 each. They ran for 43 agent-minutes in total.
- The orchestrator used 0.24 M output tokens, 94.3 M cache-read tokens and 1.37 M cache-write tokens, about $35.

Orchestrator. The orchestrating session's own token use on 23 October is not in the surviving logs, because that part of the session's history was compacted. Comparing it with the fully logged work of 26 October, we estimate it at $100–200 at list prices.

Total. API-list-price equivalent of roughly $350–450. Prices are Anthropic's published API prices as of 26 October 2026, with cache writes priced at the one-hour rate. The work actually ran within the entrant's Claude subscription, so these figures measure usage rather than money spent.

Human time. About two hours on 23 October, by the entrant's estimate. That covered reading the AI's reports and the essay, supplying eleven PDFs (the target and ten sources), typesetting, and the short messages quoted above. Add about half an hour on 26 October.

Records

The project folder holds a running log (`_NOTES.md`). It records every step, every source read, every human input with its classification at the time, and every dead end. The folder also holds:

- all drafts;
- every Q&A suggestion and triage document;
- every screening report;
- the scripts used for checking.

Two supplementary files go with this report.

- `agent-prompts.md` gives the verbatim prompt for each of the 43 agents.

- `process-records-redacted.zip` contains the running log, the idea memo, the advisor and priority-check reports, all thirty Q&A suggestions with the three triage documents, and all seven screening reports. The only redaction replaces the human's initials with "the human".

The agents' full session transcripts are kept and can be supplied on request.